

Greek myths

Some of the oldest and best-known stories in the world are the myths of Ancient Greece. They are tales of gods and heroes, great loves, wars, daring adventures, and fabulous beasts. Some of them are told here. To the Greeks of long ago, the myths and the gods who appeared in them were very real.

THE GREEK GODS

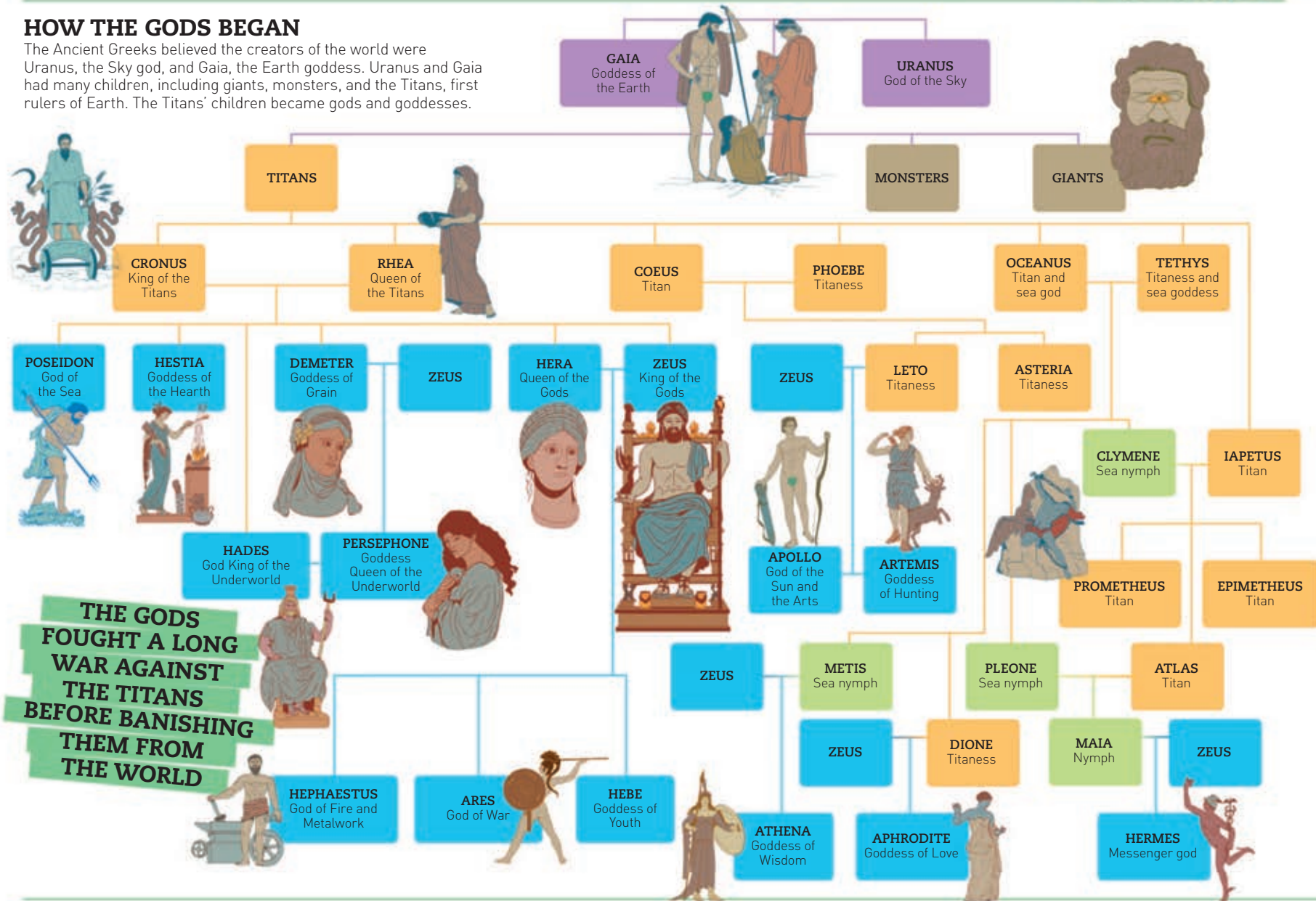
In Greek mythology, the gods were powerful supernatural beings who could make anything and everything happen. There were 12 major gods and goddesses, of whom Zeus was king. The gods lived in their palaces on the top of snow-capped Mount Olympus, the highest mountain in Greece.



MOUNT OLYMPUS

HOW THE GODS BEGAN

The Ancient Greeks believed the creators of the world were Uranus, the Sky god, and Gaia, the Earth goddess. Uranus and Gaia had many children, including giants, monsters, and the Titans, first rulers of Earth. The Titans' children became gods and goddesses.



THE UNDERWORLD

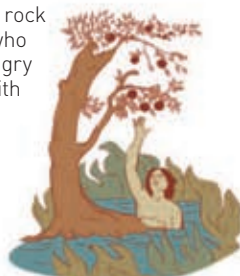
In the myths of Ancient Greece, the realm of the dead was known as the Underworld, a shadowy kingdom ruled by the god Hades. There were demons and monsters there. One of the most frightening was the three-headed dog Cerberus, who stood guard at the gates. The souls of those who had died were ferried to the Underworld in a boat across an ink-black river called the Styx.



CERBERUS

PUNISHMENTS FROM THE GODS

Many people were condemned to perpetual punishment in the Underworld because they had offended the gods. For example, Sisyphus, who had tried to become immortal, was made to push a huge rock uphill for ever. Tantalus, who insulted the gods, felt hungry and thirsty all the time, with food and drink just out of his reach.



TANTALUS

MYTHICAL BEINGS

Ancient Greek tales were full of weird creatures. There were beings called satyrs that had the upper body of a man but a lower half like a hairy goat, with hooves instead of feet. More noble were the wise centaurs, who were half man, half horse. A fire-breathing monster called the Chimaera was part lion and part goat, and had a serpent for a tail.



SATYRS